Sarkar’? Sushma Swaraj preferred the latter slogan because she felt that the party must be kept ahead of any personality cult. She was overruled by the Shah–Jaitley duo (some insiders even credit Shah with the original Abki Baar Modi Sarkar idea). Jaitley pulled out surveys which showed Modi’s popularity well above that of the BJP. ‘This election is presidential, let’s keep it that way,’ was the overall consensus.

Three weeks later, party president Rajnath Singh went ahead and tweeted, ‘Time for Change, Time for BJP, *Bahut Hui Mehngai ki Maar, Abki Baar BJP Sarkar*.’ Within minutes, he had withdrawn the tweet, and twitted ‘time for Modi’. In 2014, there was no escaping the Modi factor. The man, in a sense, was the message, artfully packaged. His face would dominate every creative.

The overarching campaign tag line had been clinched. Pandey and team now got down to preparing the creatives. The first outdoor hoarding came up on 7 March at 5.30 a.m. on Delhi’s Minto Road. The copy was simple —‘*Janata Maaf Nahi Karegi. Bahut Hua Bhrastachar, Abki Baar Modi Sarkar!’* (The voter will not forgive. Enough of corruption, time for Modi government.) ‘Mehngai’

(inflation) and ‘Bhrastachar’ (corruption) would be recurring themes to reflect public disgust against UPA 2.

The first week of March, was, as Pandey puts it, ‘crazily exhausting’. A 100 television commercial spots—ten each in different languages—were shot in a span of ten days. ‘We shot them as black-and-white commercials with “real” people speaking in their local language. We wanted the idea that the average man on the street was angry to resonate,’ says Pandey. Phase one of the campaign had been unleashed on the nation.

Then came a real brainwave. The World T20 was starting in Bangladesh on 16 March through to 6 April. Pandey was a cricket addict, having played Ranji Trophy for Rajasthan. Jaitley had been involved in cricket administration for years. ‘Why don’t we create a political campaign around cricket and push it on Star Sports while the Cup is on,’ was Pandey’s suggestion. In a cricket-crazy country, it was the perfect pitch.